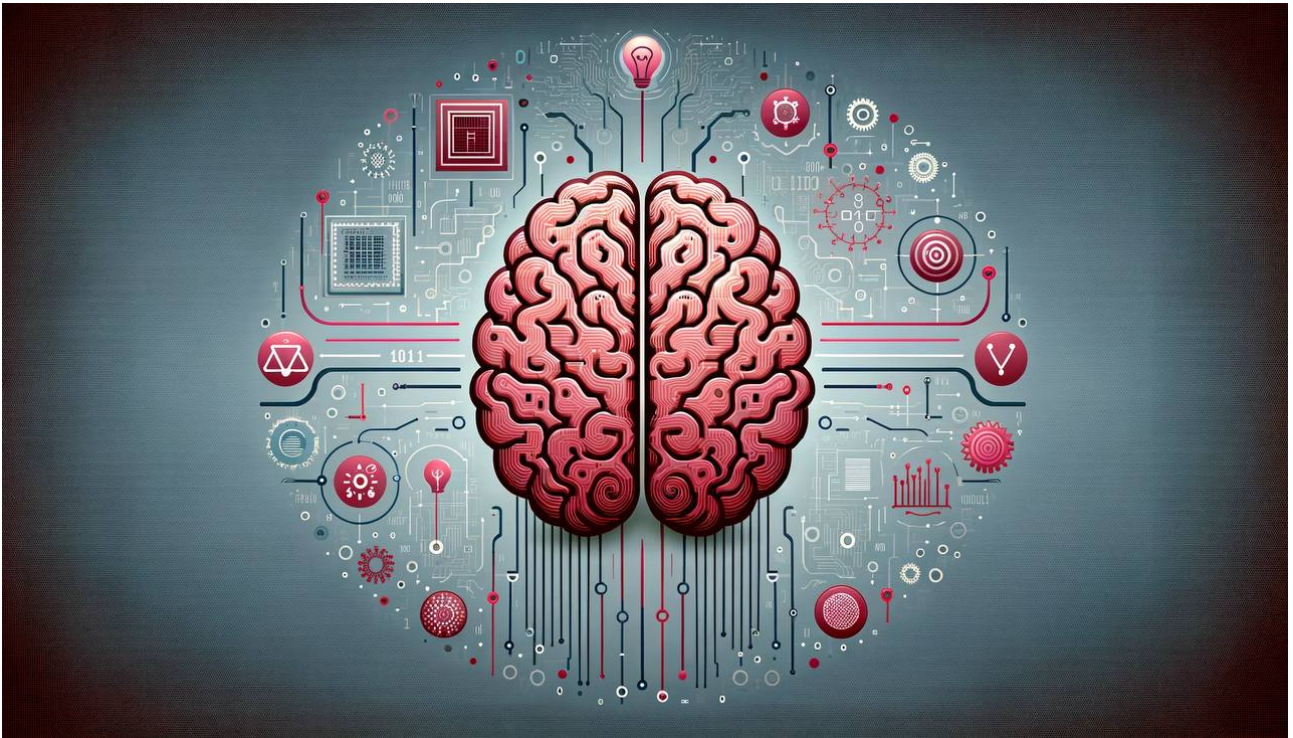


Introducing Playfulness at Work

Practical ideas and examples for teams and organisations



Cover image provided by client

Introducing playfulness at work is not about turning the office into a playground. It is about creating small, regular moments of curiosity, experimentation, and lightness that feel natural and connected to real work. When done well, these moments improve engagement, creativity, and team cohesion without adding unnecessary overhead.

Below are practical ideas and examples that can be directly applied within teams and organisations.

1. Playful Meetings and Rituals

Routine interactions offer the easiest entry point for introducing play. The goal is not to add extra tasks, but to slightly reshape existing ones.

Warm-up “silly” check-ins

At the start of a weekly stand-up, introduce quick, low-pressure prompts:

- “If our project were a movie, what would the title be?”
- “What emoji describes your energy today?”

Each person shares in 10–15 seconds. This creates a signal that humour and self-expression are welcome.

Play-based ice-breakers in workshops

Before a strategy session, ask participants to draw a quick comic strip of “the perfect customer journey” using only three stick-figure panels. No artistic skill is required. The goal is to trigger storytelling and laughter while easing people into creative thinking.

Internal “game rounds” in meetings

Introduce a 5-minute “What-If?” game:

- “What if our competitors suddenly disappeared for 6 months?”
- “What if we had to deliver this project using only 3 people?”

Participants write ideas on sticky notes or a shared slide, then vote on the funniest or most creative responses. This encourages lateral thinking in a safe, playful format.

2. Playful Team-Building in Context (Ireland, HR/Tech)

Play works best when it reflects the team’s identity and working rhythm.

“Culture hacks” challenge

Run a monthly mini-competition: “Design one tiny ritual that makes our team feel more human.”

Example: A Dublin-based team introduced a “Coffee & Curiosity” 20-minute session every Friday. Anyone can share a non-HR book, podcast, or AI tool they explored. The winner selects the next theme, such as wellbeing, productivity, or AI in HR.

Props-based retrospectives

Reframe retrospectives using simple prompts instead of standard formats.

Instead of “What went well / what could improve,” give participants cards:

- “Win” (stories of success)
- “Oops” (mistakes that taught something)
- “Surprise” (unexpected moments)

People share briefly, then vote on the most memorable story. This keeps reflection engaging while still productive.

3. Playful HR / People-Team Practices

For HR teams, play can be embedded directly into core processes.

Recruitment “fun filter”

Include one light, revealing question in interviews:

- “Tell me about a time you had fun at work and what you learned from it.”

This communicates that the organisation values more than technical competence.

Onboarding “adventure” map

Replace long onboarding checklists with a simple “week-one quest”:

- “Find 3 colleagues and learn one thing about their life outside work.”
- “Ask someone about a mistake they made and what they learned.”

This turns early networking into a playful scavenger hunt and accelerates connection-building.

Playful recognition rituals

Create a low-formality channel or board called “Tiny Wins & Tall Tales”, where people share moments like:

- “Today I debugged a spreadsheet that cursed at me.”
- “Helped a colleague through a technical meltdown; we now call it ‘Team Exorcism’.”

This type of recognition is human, memorable, and often more meaningful than formal awards.

4. Making Play a Core Part of Work

To move beyond occasional activities, play needs to be structured into how teams operate.

Play as a design principle

Integrate it into existing workflows:

- Start quarterly planning with 10 minutes of “absurd idea generation” (e.g., “What if we had unlimited budget and no rules?”)
- Then ask: “What one wild idea can we scale down to reality?”

Leaders model playfulness

Leadership behaviour sets the tone. Simple actions include:

- Starting meetings with three minutes for a non-work-related story or GIF
- Sharing a personal “glitch of the week” to normalise imperfection

Measure and iterate, not remove

Use short anonymous pulse questions:

- “How often do you feel our team has fun while working?”
- “Which ritual made you smile this month?”

Keep what works, and remove what feels forced.

5. A Simple Starter Kit (You Can Use This Week)

Here are three no-cost ideas to try immediately:

1. Emoji mood check-in

At the start of your next team call, ask everyone to share one emoji that reflects their current state.

2. Three-word story

Take a 5-minute creative break where each person adds a three-word sentence to a shared story: "Dogs invaded the office..." Continue until it becomes a ridiculous mini-plot.

3. Playful feedback

End a meeting with one question: "What is one fun thing we could try differently next time?" Write responses down and commit to trying at least one.

Final Thought

Playfulness does not compete with productivity. When introduced thoughtfully, it strengthens how teams communicate, experiment, and learn. The key is consistency, relevance, and keeping it lightweight.